land-based targets and civilian populations could now be targeted. The US preference for containing the conflict in the global commons was at risk of being overtaken by events. Standard operating procedures at US Strategic Command, which controlled America's nuclear arsenal, had moved readiness on September 10 from peacetime Defense Condition (DEFCON) 5 to DEFCON 4, and then on September 12 to DEFCON 3, with enhanced readiness at underground missile silos and the ability to mobilize nuclear-armed bombers on ground alert. The PLA Rocket Force went to high alert on September 11, and a JIN-class nuclear ballistic missile submarine carrying the JL-2 submarine-launched ballistic missile sortied from its base at Longpo on Hainan Island, to join a counterpart already on patrol. When US Strategic Command obtained satellite imagery of the empty submarine wharves on Hainan on September 12, its commander ordered the USS *Louisiana* (SSBN-743) out of Bremerton, Washington, to join the USS *Kentucky* (SSBN-737), already on patrol in the Pacific.

After the Battle of the Senkakus, the expansion of the war to land-based, populated targets became the next logical military step, but one that US political and senior military leaders were loath to take. With the increase in readiness of strategic forces, use of nuclear force itself no longer seemed unthinkable, given the emotionalism likely to break out in both countries at the destruction of the aircraft carriers, the most visible symbols of their military power. More worrisome for operations planners in both countries was the likelihood that the Americans would begin targeting mobile DF-21D and DF-26 launchers on China's mainland to prevent the PLA from using any more antiship ballistic missiles. Such attacks would force the Chinese to begin attacking ground targets in response, possibly in Guam and even Hawaii, as well as in Japan, where US air and naval forces were based. Japanese policy makers braced themselves for a wave of Chinese ballistic missile attacks as a tactic to pressure Tokyo to abandon its American ally.

Unexpectedly, perhaps, the first steps toward a cessation of hostilities were proposed by the Chinese. The Chinese attack on the *Gerald Ford*, in mistaken retaliation for the *Liaoning* disabling, caused a rift in